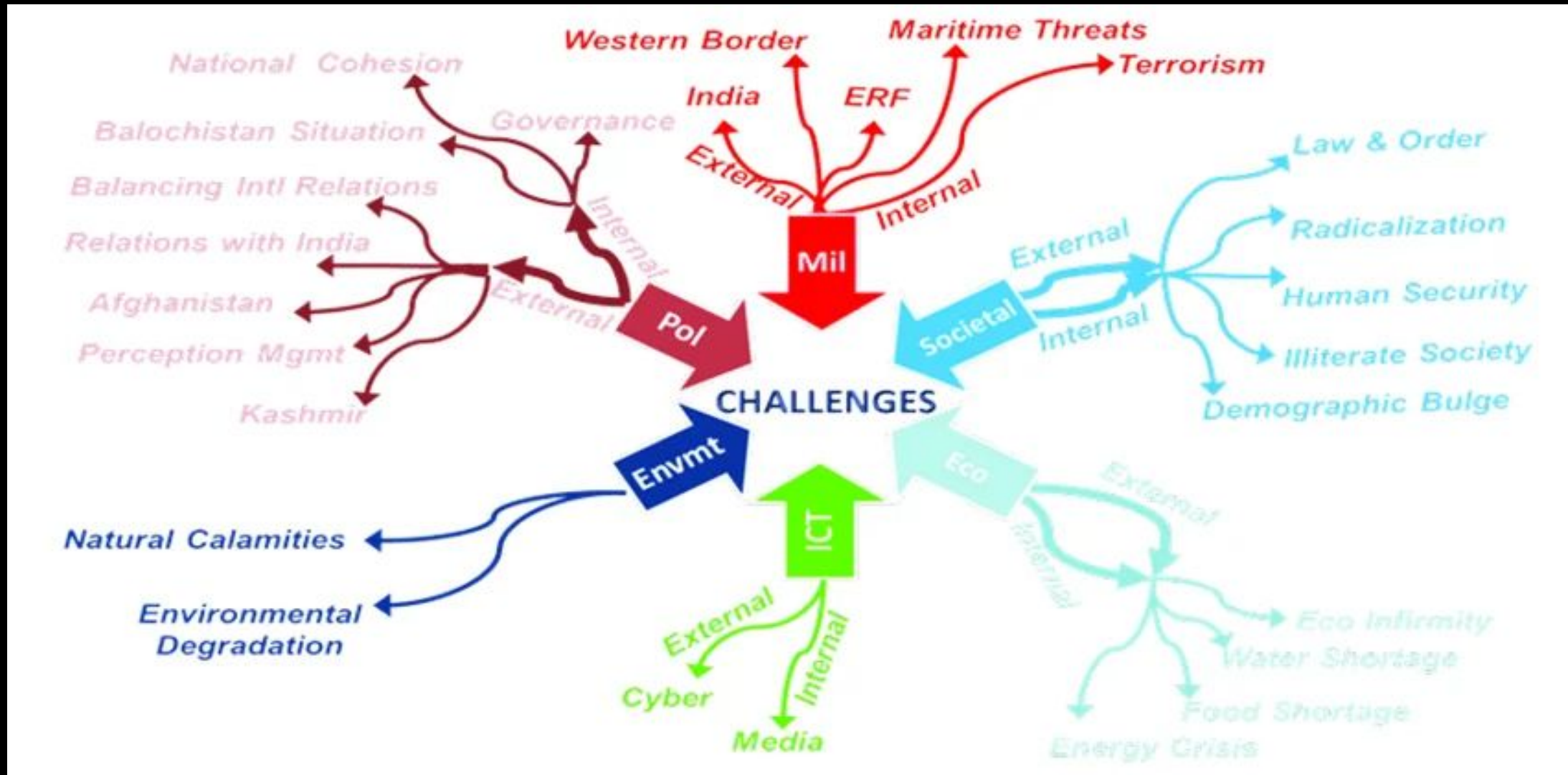


Week 11- Lecture 01 & 02

Pakistan National Security; External and Internal Traditional Security Dynamics



Introduction

Pakistan has traditionally been focused on traditional threats to its sovereignty, mainly arising from India. However, with the passage of time, the nature of threats to the country has undergone a thorough transformation with hostile nations and groups, not choosing direct offensive against the state, rather choosing cyber space, proxy wars, internal fissures as a tool to further their nefarious designs. Moreover, serious threats have emerged from climate change owing to the excessive use of fossil fuels. Additionally, the deep transformation in the political philosophy of nations from a state-centric approach to a citizen-centric approach has led to the need to consider human security. So the country is facing both conventional and non-conventional threats emerging from inside the territory and outside the territory. However, successive governments have perceived these threats and have devised policies to address the national security challenges in a timely and effective manner. In short, the country faces multiple threats from multiple fronts of multiple natures, including its sovereignty and integrity.

EVOLUTION OF NATIONAL SECURITY THREATS

In international relations, the term 'security' is diverse, and a single definition is not able to encompass its different aspects. Moreover, with the inclusion of terrorism and guerrilla wars, the concept of security gets more diversified. In general, security is protection from all kinds of threats, be it external or internal in nature. **David A. Baldwin, a senior political scientist at Princeton University, argues that threats to nation-states in the contemporary era are not limited to traditional ones, but also include non-traditional threats like poverty, trade, economy, and human rights.** Traditional threats are considered armed conflicts, where an increase in military might is perceived to be a reliable solution. However, the non-traditional threats do not actively involve harming civilians through weapons, but they involve hurting a population through economic woes, human rights concerns, environmental degradation, and political instability. In non-traditional threats, states in order to address them pursue a strategy of building a robust economy, ensuring justice for all, providing general welfare to their populations, and protecting the environment from excessive pollution-causing activities. Pakistan currently faces both traditional and non-traditional threats.

Pakistan's Traditional Security Challenges

A- External Traditional Security Challenges

- **Aggressive Neighbors: India's Cold Start Doctrine**

India has historically been the country's largest external conventional threat, making it the focal point of Pakistan Army's military planning and security calculations. With the passage of time, the success of negotiations and dialogues has seemed futile with India becoming more belligerent in its posture and language vis-à-vis Pakistan. Its doctrinal tactics, like 'limited war under nuclear overhaul' and 'cold start doctrine' presents the offensive designs of the Indian state which it cherishes against its western neighbor. In response to India's cold start strategy, Pakistan shifted its nuclear doctrine of 'nuclear restraint regime' to 'credible minimum deterrence' to deter its foe from any military escalation. Moreover, India's hefty military spending for troops' modernization further widens the conventional asymmetry between India and Pakistan. In short, India's ambitions to become a regional hegemon arising from its excessive pride in its economy and military might, fueled by its political leadership, add to the growing conventional threat to Pakistan.

- **Cross-border Terrorism in Pakistan**

Pakistan has been confronting the threat of cross-border terrorism for many years, both from its eastern and western neighbors. Terrorists and non-state actors sneak into the Pakistani territory to execute their nefarious designs of creating chaos and instability by bombing, target killings, and attacking security installations. It has taken a heavy toll of civilians and military personnel, along with significant infrastructure damages. **The arrest of India's spy, Kulbhushan Yadev, from Balochistan found in espionage and sabotage activities against Pakistan** clearly reflects the looming threat of intrusion of militants and foreign agents of hostile countries into the territory of Pakistan to thwart the stability of the state. Similarly, the infiltration of terrorists from Afghanistan's territory has been a serious threat that has resulted in significant devastation and destruction in the country for decades. Afghanistan has become a safe haven for a number of terrorist groups, including Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), who frequently launch terror attacks inside Pakistan's territory, claiming the lives of many noncombatants and armed forces personnel, along with infrastructure destruction. A recent United Nations report by the UN Sanctions Monitoring Team in July 2024 says **"the TTP continues to operate at a significant scale in Afghanistan and conduct terrorist operations into Pakistan from there, often utilizing Afghans"**. Such reports substantiate Pakistan's claims of cross-border terrorism from its western neighbor. Pakistan has repeatedly raised its voice on international platforms about its threat of cross-border terrorism from its western neighbor and has also urged the Afghan government to take stern actions against these terror outfits operating from its soil, though the Afghan leadership seems hesitant to proceed. [**📍 Pakistan Affairs Resources**](#)

- **Insurgency in Balochistan**

Insurgency in the Balochistan is considered a conventional threat to the stability of the country, partly attributed to external factors, particularly India, in boasting the insurgents and helping them financially. The hostile countries, in their way to fulfil their evil agendas against Pakistan, use these insurgents as a launching pad to bring instability in the country. India's overt involvement in disintegration of Pakistan's eastern wing, now Bangladesh, is a clear precedent of India's involvement in the domestic affairs of a foreign country, a grave violation of the UN Charter (UNGA 2131XX 1965) on external interferences. Moreover, subsequent admission by India's Prime Minister, Narendra Modi, on India's involvement in the support of Mukti-Bahini and resultant dismemberment of Pakistan's eastern wing testifies Pakistan's claims. Pakistan has repeatedly raised this issue of India's involvement in fueling the insurgency in Balochistan on international forums, including the United Nations (UN). For India, China Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) and China's growing presence in a number of South Asian countries, including Pakistan, are a subject of worry, which is reflected from **A K Antony's, Defense Minister of India, statement in a 2013 press conference that "It is a matter of concern for India" that China is taking control of Gwadar port in Arabian Sea.** Keeping in view the destabilizing role of eastern neighbor in the country, **Pakistan's Permanent Representative to the UN, Maleeha Lodhi, submitted a dossier to the UN Secretary General, Antonio Guterres, in January 2017 containing evidence of India's involvement in terrorist activities in Balochistan, FATA, and Karachi.** So, the insurgency in Balochistan, though rooted in historical grievances, is fanned by the external players, mainly India, to bring perpetual chaos and instability in the country.

- **Preference Towards Regionalism and Sub Nationalist Tendencies**

Pakistan, since its inception, inherited the preference of regional identities and affiliations due to different federating units willingly opting to join Pakistan. However, at the national scene, despite concerted efforts, the ideal interprovincial harmony could not be created. While such a diversity could have been capitalized as one nation with different colors, but unfortunately, a holistic outlook is far from reality. The grievances of smaller federating units and the failure of central government in addressing their legitimate concerns and instead of using hard power in crushing those sentiments have led to polarization and dissatisfaction in the current structure of federation. The marginalized segments of society have resorted to armed struggle, especially in Baluchistan and former FATA areas. Continued neglect, parochial political interests, tribal ethos, and weak governance has been exploited by the anti-state elements and supported by their foreign masters, which has given rise to sub-nationalism and a radical culture that thrives on brutality, vandalism thus eroding the social fabrics and national integration in the country.

B. INTERNAL TRADITIONAL SECURITY CHALLENGES

- **Terrorist Organizations**

Pakistan's biggest internal security threat is the scourge of terrorism, which it has been facing for past 20 years. **According to National Counter Terrorism Authority (NACTA), terrorist-related activities have taken 83 thousand lives and incurred a financial loss of more than 35 trillion rupees.** Similarly, terrorism has inflicted colossal damage to infrastructure. Currently, **Pakistan ranks fourth in Global Terrorism Index (GTI) with deaths due to terrorist-related activities mounting by 35 per cent to 689 from 2022 to 2023.** In response to the menace, the government has banned 78 militant organizations and has resorted to strict punitive measures against them. In short, terrorism has remained a major internal security threat to the country.

- **Sectarian Violence**

It is another menace that threatens Pakistan's stability. Extremism and Sectarianism took its roots due to the Saudi-Iran rivalry, and Zia's Islamization measures. Consequently, sectarian violence took the lives of thousands of individuals, mostly Shia Muslims, instigated by Sipah-e-Sahaba Pakistan (SSP) and its offshoot, Laskar-e-Jhangvi (LeT). Subsequently, Salafi Islamic State Khorasan Province (ISKP) has also emerged, further intensifying the threat. **In March 2022, ISKP bombed a Shia mosque in Peshawar, claiming the lives of 60 people.** Moreover, **in 2023, a total of 203 people, including 88 armed personnel, have been killed in sectarian violence-related activities.** In short, sectarian violence is a grave internal security threat that needs the government's serious attention.

- **Organized Crimes**

Organized crime (OC) is recognized by NSP (2022-26) as an important internal security threat to the country's metropolitan areas, business atmosphere and overall economy and has prioritized the objective of combating organized crime in the country. **According to Global Organized Crime Index (GOCI), Pakistan's criminality score is 6.03 out of 10, placing the country on 47th position in 193 members list and 3rd in 8 South Asian nations.** The reason that emboldens these groups, involved in OCs, such as human trafficking, organ trafficking, arms trafficking, illicit mining and drug trade, is that they are supported by corrupt government officials, mafia-style groups, criminal networks, and well-known groups, like People's Aman Committee and Altaf Khanani's money laundering organization. Among other types of OC, arms trafficking is a serious issue that has increased violence due to the easy availability of abundant unlicensed arms in a few areas of the country, like Dara Adam Khel, where low-quality weapons are produced, often utilized by criminals and terrorist groups. Moreover, mafia groups in Pakistan are engaged in activities like racketeering, extortion, and kidnappings. Owing to the strong connections these groups have with authorities, they operate in a friendly environment without any fear of a crackdown from LEAs. In a nutshell, the evil of organized crimes is a serious evil that has threatened the country's socioeconomic and security landscape.

- **Pakistan's Internal Security Mosaic**

The internal security mosaic for Pakistan presents a fractured image of Pakistani society.

Identity-based on language, tribe, province, and ethnicity have resurfaced in underdeveloped regions of Pakistan. The notion of deprivation and marginalization are fracturing our society, as they feel left out from the radar screen of Islamabad.

Sectarianism and economic instability are yet other important variables negatively impacting the internal fissures posing serious threats to the internal security of Pakistan. Religious extremism, on the other hand, has produced an unpleasant image within and

Interprovincial disharmony, feelings of deprivation, and marginalization has led to armed struggle in Baluchistan and former FATA with simmering effects in interior Sindh as well. There have been instances of armed insurgency by a handful of tribal leaders and counter-insurgency operations by security forces in Baluchistan and former FATA. The armed groups with their hide outs in "NO GO" areas in Baluchistan and adjacent Afghanistan are a constant source of threat. While successive governments have won electoral benefits by voicing solidarity with such deprived communities like Aghaz e Haqqo QE Baluchistan, but little was done on the ground to alleviate their sufferings and mainstream them through equitable economic development.

The deficiency of equitable socioeconomic development has provided ethno sectarian elements and regional forces cases belief to exploit these inadequacies and internally weaken the federation of Pakistan through protracted low intensity conflict. The ethno sectarian glitches are serious threats to the internal security mosaic of Pakistan.

• **Reassessment of National Integration Matrix**

Political polarization, intolerance, and depleting respect for other's views and manifestos have added fragility to the national harmony. Receding economic opportunities, rising Inflation, unemployment, and a growing number of population sliding below the poverty line are seriously impacting the internal cohesion and nationhood of Pakistani society.

Even though Pakistan was created in the name of Islam after enormous sacrifices and human sufferings, yet even after 74 years of independence, we have not been able to gel ourselves as a homogenous society. The gap between State and society is widening, and the social contract is weakening, thus eroding the pride of Pakistani society. The successive governments also made little effort in seriously addressing the frustration of underprivileged segments of society, and today, this ever-growing monster of disunity is hurting the very foundations of our existence as a nation-state. The undermentioned diagram recapitulates the existing national integration predicaments for us, which are also examined in detail in the ensuing paragraphs.

- **Political Polarization**

Pakistan's political history and governance is rich in forms and manifestations. More than half of the time since the country's inception in 1947 has been ruled by the military, and out of remaining time, we have witnessed controlled democracy, party, and nonparty basis elections and full democracy. The critical examination of different types of governance along with their time durations lead us to conclude that no system was perfect, and since then, the country has been facing the perpetual State of experiments.

Theoretically, the mainstream political parties are a symbol of national unity and integration, but unfortunately, due to the feeling of expulsion, they have opted to limit their electoral desires within their native constituencies. The vacuum at the national level was initially exploited by the religious extremist parties and later by those championing provincialism and regionalism while resorting to low-intensity conflicts to achieve their political ends.

There is yet another phenomenon of political intolerance and lack of respect for others' views, which has fractured the civilized norms and outlook of Pakistani society. Today the national political scene is presenting a dreadful picture, where impatience, intolerance, abusive language, allegations, and the blame game is shaping the behavior of political parties and inculcating the culture of hatred, parochial provincialism, ethnicity, tribalism, feudalism, thus creating a serious dent in the national identity and self-esteem of Pakistani nation.

While several slogans have been articulated by political elites addressing the socio-economic issues of the masses, however, people have always been ignored when any party has been elevated to govern through the electoral process. The mindset of the ruling elite, which has nurtured since independence, remained one of “colonial” character, designed to control people instead of becoming an instrument for self-government. The evolving paradigm presents a very grim picture of the national integration matrix as the political point-scoring at the cost of national development and subduing each other are the new norms of our political discourse, which is negatively impacting our identity, assimilation, and dignity.

- **Ideological Character of State**

As per Stephen P Cohen, “The most significant struggle in Pakistan is not a civilizational clash between Muslims and non-Muslims, but a clatter between diverse conceptions and interpretations of Islam, predominantly how Pakistan should implement Islamic identity in State’s outlook”. Even after 74 years of independence, the ideological construct of the State is still being debated by almost all the political parties, especially the religio-political parties. Unfortunately, the State's Islamic ideology is a point of debate since our independence and has become a very sensitive issue over a period, that has made the society intolerant, and has deflected the policymakers from core concerns of socio-economic development and wellbeing of the society.

• **Religious Extremism**

The sectarianism and religious extremism have grown as the most complicated challenge to the national integration, security, and stability of Pakistan. The urge to impose their version and interpretation of Islam has acted as a fundamental cause of disharmony in the society. It is worth noting that various political parties and other forms of governance in Pakistan for their perceived interests used the religious card to advance their political motivations and agendas. Instead of unifying the nation under one religious identity enshrined by Islam, such myopic religious discourse has divided us on intolerant societal characteristics, fueling hatred and discord as the State and society has delegated the religious interpretation to clergy, which offered them the monopoly over religious issues. The revolution in Iran, Afghan jihad, Talibanization and recent victory of Taliban and reinstatement of their government in Kabul has recharged aspiring religio-political entities to resort to militancy for accruing political leverage. The federal capital has virtually become a battle ground for all religious and political protests, where life comes to a grinding halt at frequent intervals. The writ of the government is challenged by every such gatherings and each time the State has surrendered to the demands of protesters to an unprecedented level. The charged mob of protesters do not care about fellow citizens and brutalize the law enforcing agencies as well. The people are gradually losing trust in the governance elites due to eroding public order and safety at the hands of a handful of religious fanatics. The evolving situation if not proactively handled may polarize the society even further and promote extremism, terrorism, and hatred within Pakistan, further confounding the integration matrix.

Conclusion

Pakistan's security challenges have greatly diversified with the passage of time from initial threats coming from India to emerging threats arising from climate change, pandemics, digitalization, and human security concerns, such as food security and water security. Realizing the gravity of these threats, the country has devised several policies to combat the growing national security challenges; however, their effectiveness and success ultimately lie in the country's will and determination to implement them in true letter and spirit.